BRAND VISION, DIGITAL REALITY

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@asianartmuseum

Asian

Wednesday, 30 January 2013



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When I joined the Asian, it had a world-class collection of Asian art



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2013 is milestone year for us—it is our 10th anniversary in our home at Civic Center Plaza.

Over the past 10 years we've:

welcomed more than 2.3 million visitors,

including more than 200,000 students and teachers.

We've presented 56 special exhibitions

Published 25 books and catalogues

Added close to 2,000 artworks to the collection

Refreshed the collection galleries with 3,000 rotations



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Global financial downturn meant an institutional financial crisis

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But we were facing two major challenges

The economic downturn hit our museum hard, as it did many others

The museum didn't resonate with people

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And the museum didn't resonate with people the way it deserved to

MISCONCEPTION:

We’re a niche museum

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There was a misconception that we were a niche museum. People saw us as unfamiliar, exotic, or only appealing to people with a cultural or personal connection to Asia

MISCONCEPTION:

We’re inaccessible

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We were perceived as scholarly, inaccessible, maybe even stuffy



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So I developed a plan

PUT THE VISITOR FIRST

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To put the visitor first. All the time. In every decision.

PUTTING THE VISITOR FIRST:

Focus on the experience

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What does that mean? Well, we wanted to focus on the experience.

PUTTING THE VISITOR FIRST:

Make it personal

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Make it personal, for every visitor

PUTTING THE VISITOR FIRST:

Make it relevant

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And make it relevant – Asian for all



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It's not about one part of Asia – our collection stretches across the continent.

It's not all ancient art – we just commissioned a new contemporary work by Xu Bing.

We focus on the interconnectivity of our collection.

AWAKEN & INSPIRE

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We created a new brand that reflected where we wanted to go. But it isn't just about a new logo, it's about a brand promise.



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A year on, we've had an array of successes…

Over the last 18 months the museum has reinvented itself to engage broader audiences, and we have embraced a new vision—we aim to spark connections across cultures and through time, with art experiences that inspire new art, new creativity, and new thinking.

We are poised to welcome our 10th anniversary and start our next decade in bringing our new vision to life with possibly our most crowd-pleasing exhibition ever: *China's Terracotta Warriors: The First Emperor's Legacy*



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BUT ONE PIECE WAS MISSING

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But there was one major piece missing. Digital.

Why?



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We had digital talent but lacked digital leadership to pull together a cohesive experience. So we hired someone. And here she is.

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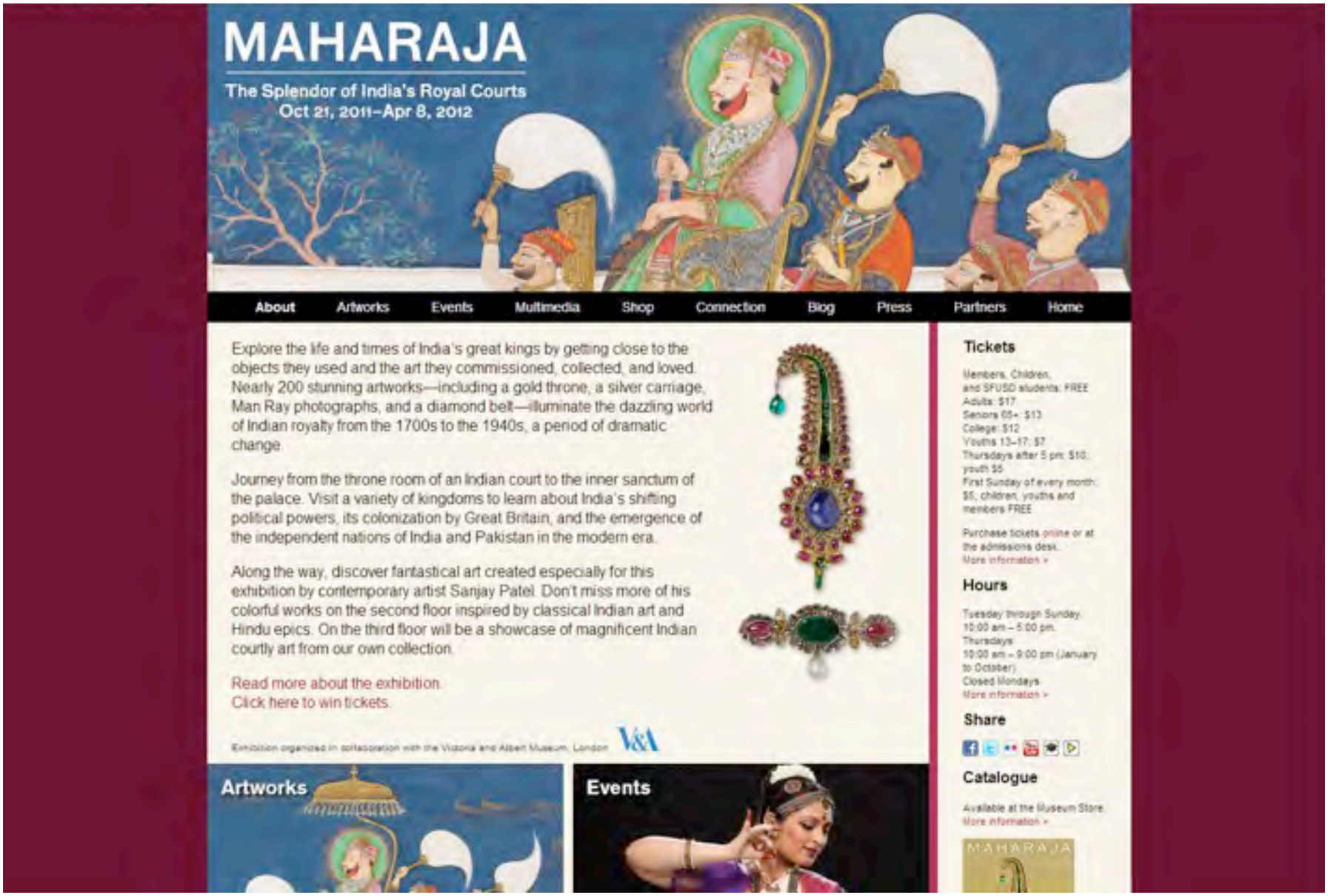
You've seen some of Jay's extraordinary vision and some of its results.



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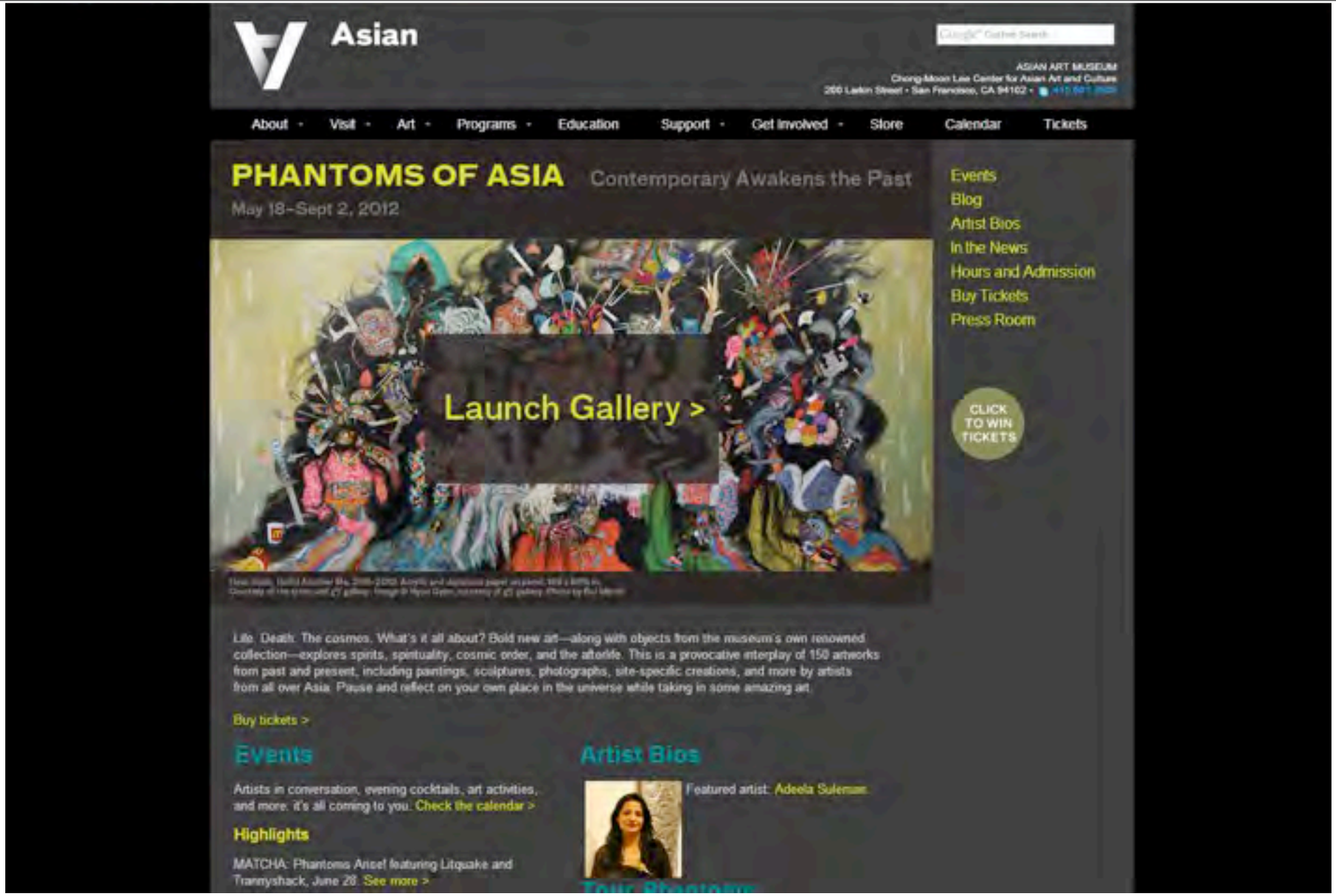
But this is where we were on the web



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This is where we were…



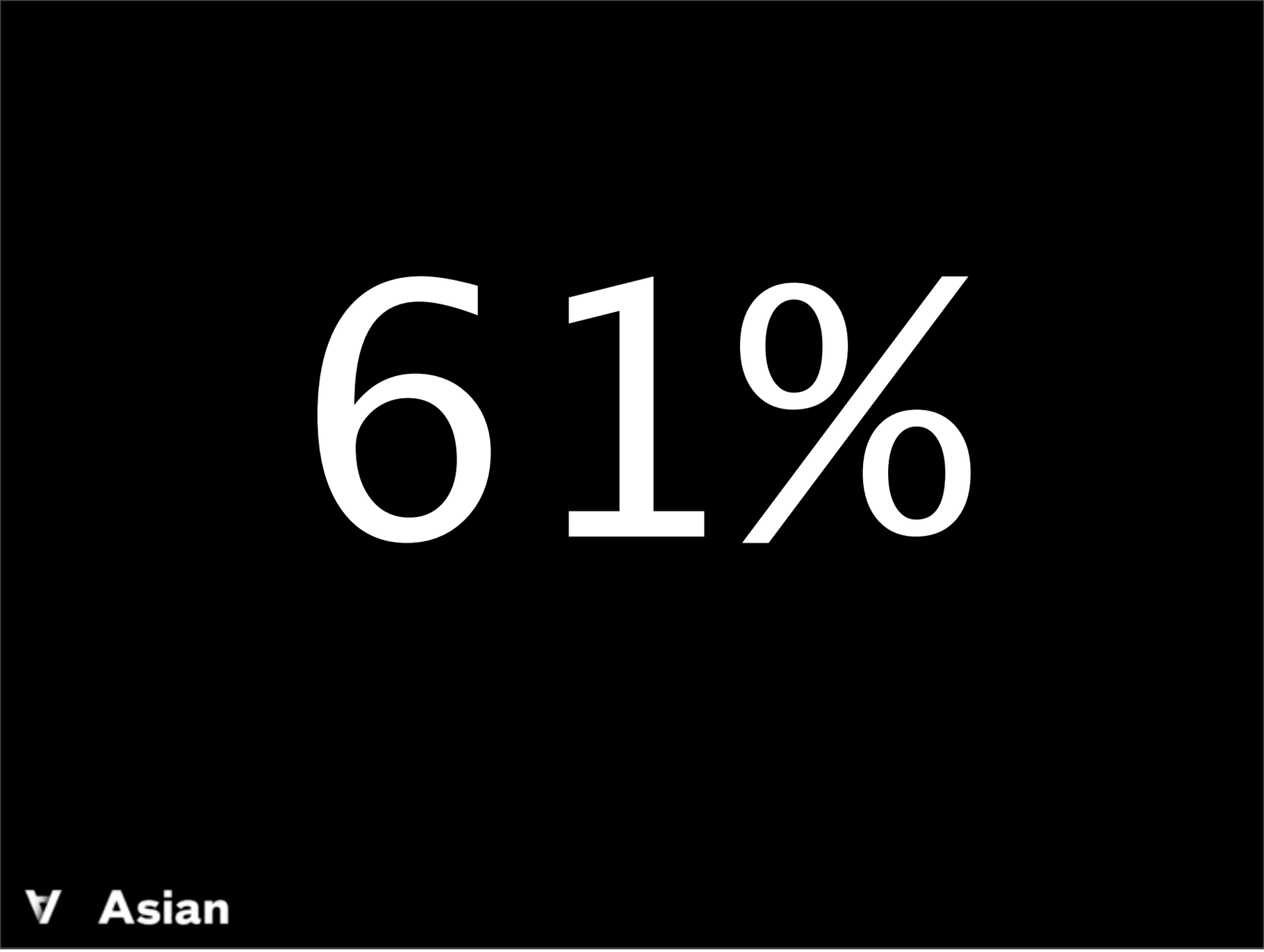
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This is where we were…

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And this is where we were on mobile.



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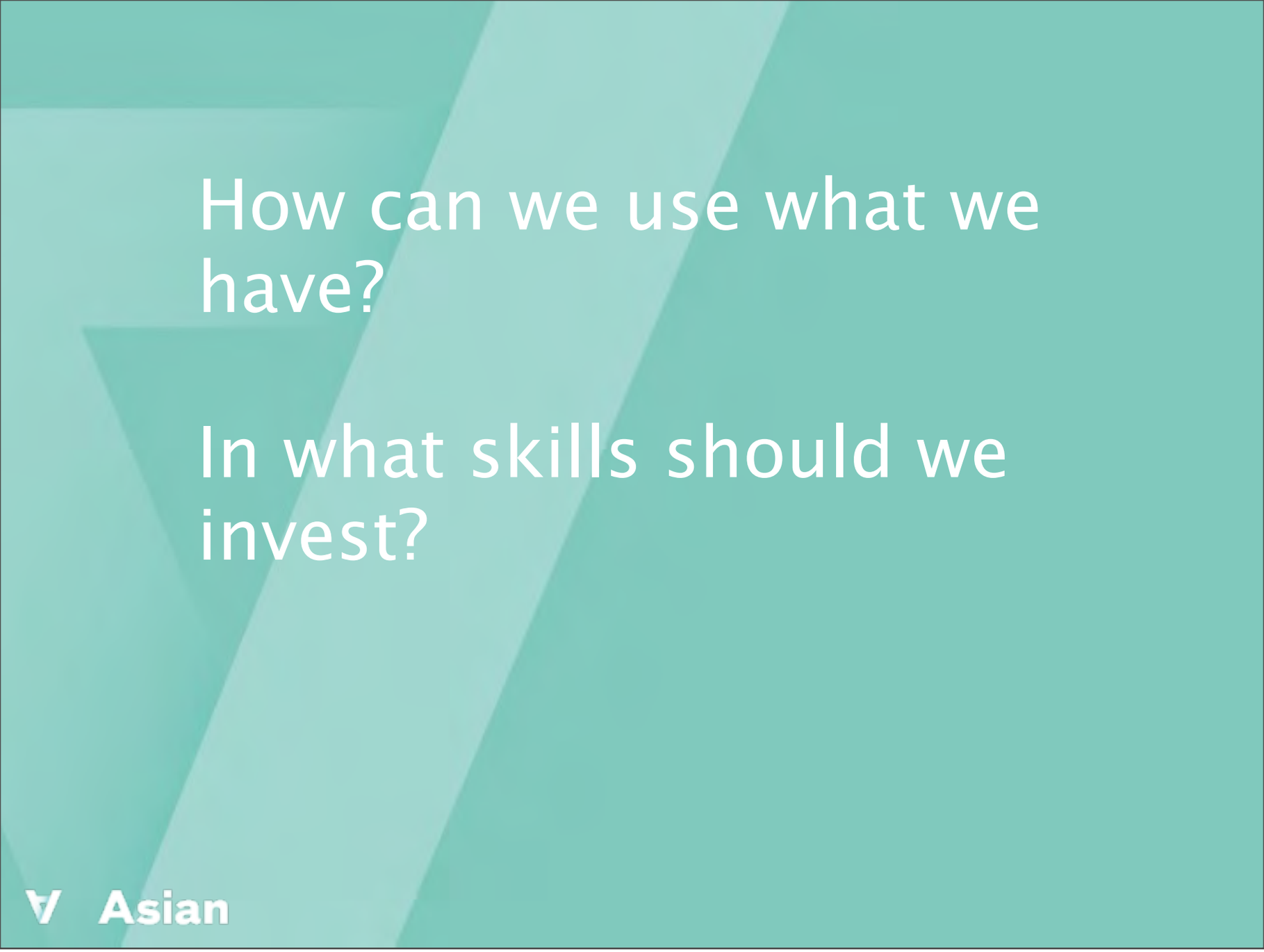
61% of our audience comes INTO THE MUSEUM with a smartphone. We had no mobile offering.

Our users were clearly signalling their needs and we were not meeting them. This was the impetus for change.

But how?

Change is widespread and organizational. It requires profound decisions about strategy.

But today I want to talk about how we took the step beyond strategy, into implementation.



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There was a clear need for us to rebrand.

So we did what museums do. We created a committee.



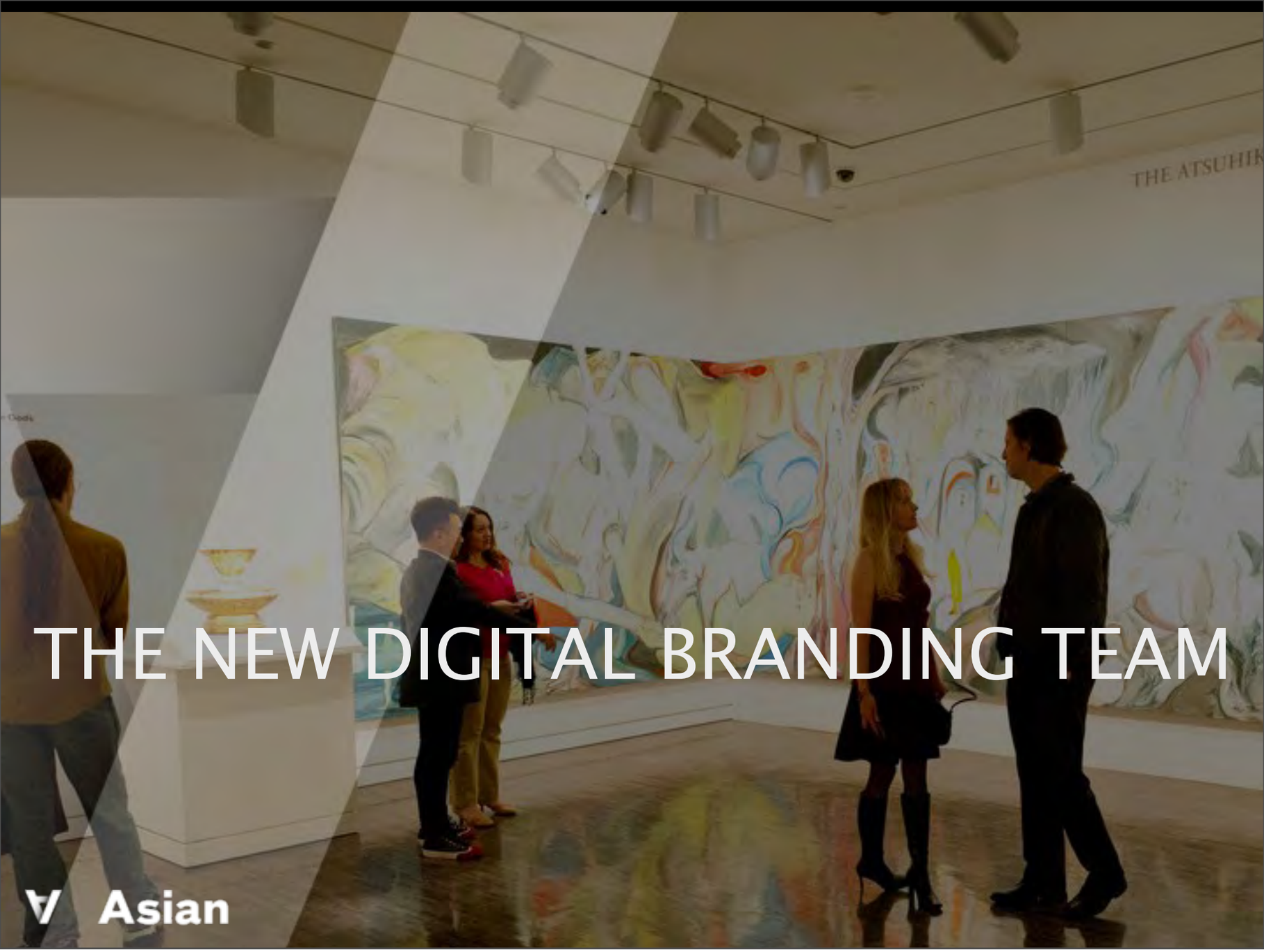
THE ORIGINAL DIGITAL BRANDING TEAM

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The digital branding team was tasked with realizing the brand in digital.
Involved all levels of the org, from the executive to the trenches.
It was a cross department team.

These were passionate, committed people who wanted to see digital work.
People went above and beyond their normal roles, drawing on their talents and interests.
But as a whole, we had the will but not the skill.

Three problems:
-Large and unwieldy, so slow to make decisions, if at all.
-Group had no clear authority.
-No clear goals or raison d'etre



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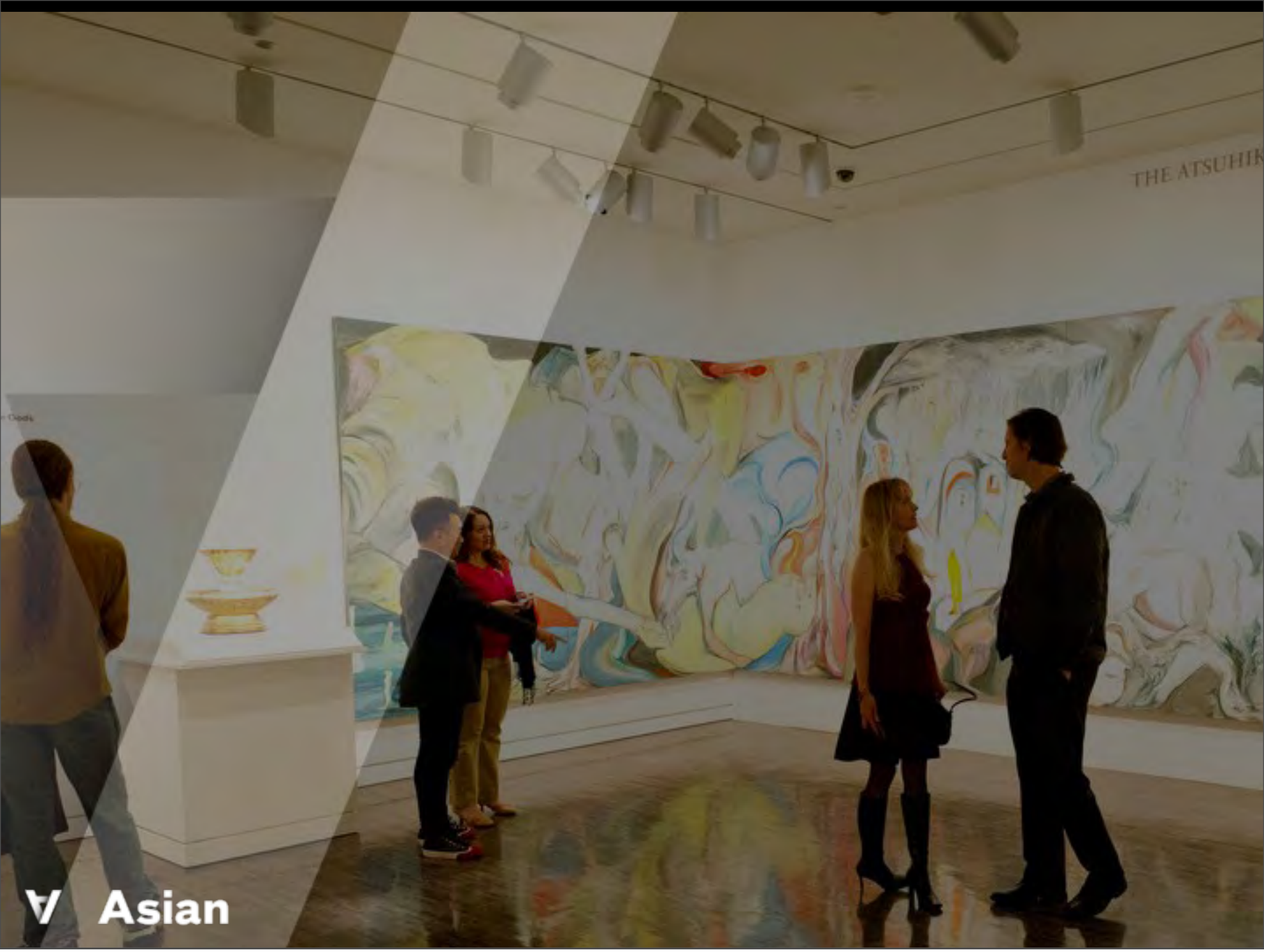
This situation needed fixing.

I analyzed the strengths and weaknesses of individuals and the team
I then broke the team up in line with people's skills and also their ability to commit time.

Created a governance layer
Senior members, steering committee. Make high-level strategic decisions.

The 3 teams by function.
Innovate, implement, improve.

Innovate: make recommendations to the steering committee about overall program of work.
Review and research proposed initiatives
Prioritize against each other and against strategy



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Our Chief Curator Forrest McGill was our most important champion. He's a storyteller. He sees the possibilities for using digital to tell stories about our collection. And he can help us to work with others around the museum who may not immediately see the potential that he does. Here's one example of where that has taken us.



Scene from the epic Ramayana: Kumbhakarna battles the monkeys, approx 1100-1150. Northeastern Thailand; former kingdom of Angkor. Sandstone. *The Avery Brundage Collection*. B66S7

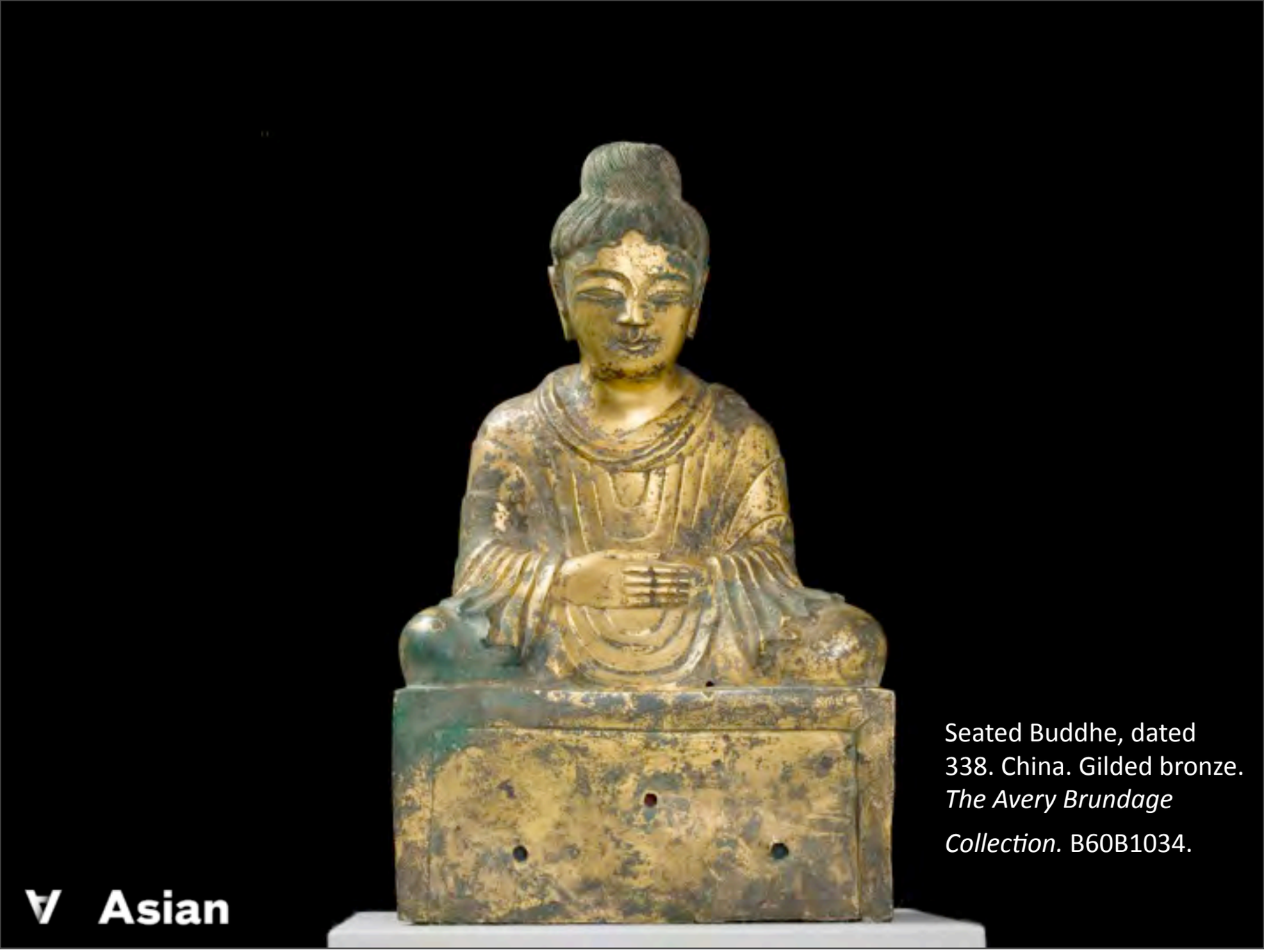
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We have a marketing goal to attract people to our collection, and we have been exploring innovative ways for people to experience the collection.

We'd also heard people talking about how 3D printing was the next big thing. And it turned out that our collection was especially suited to 3D scanning.

We have detailed works in stone



Seated Buddhe, dated 338. China. Gilded bronze. *The Avery Brundage Collection.* B60B1034.

Asian

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Richly textured objects

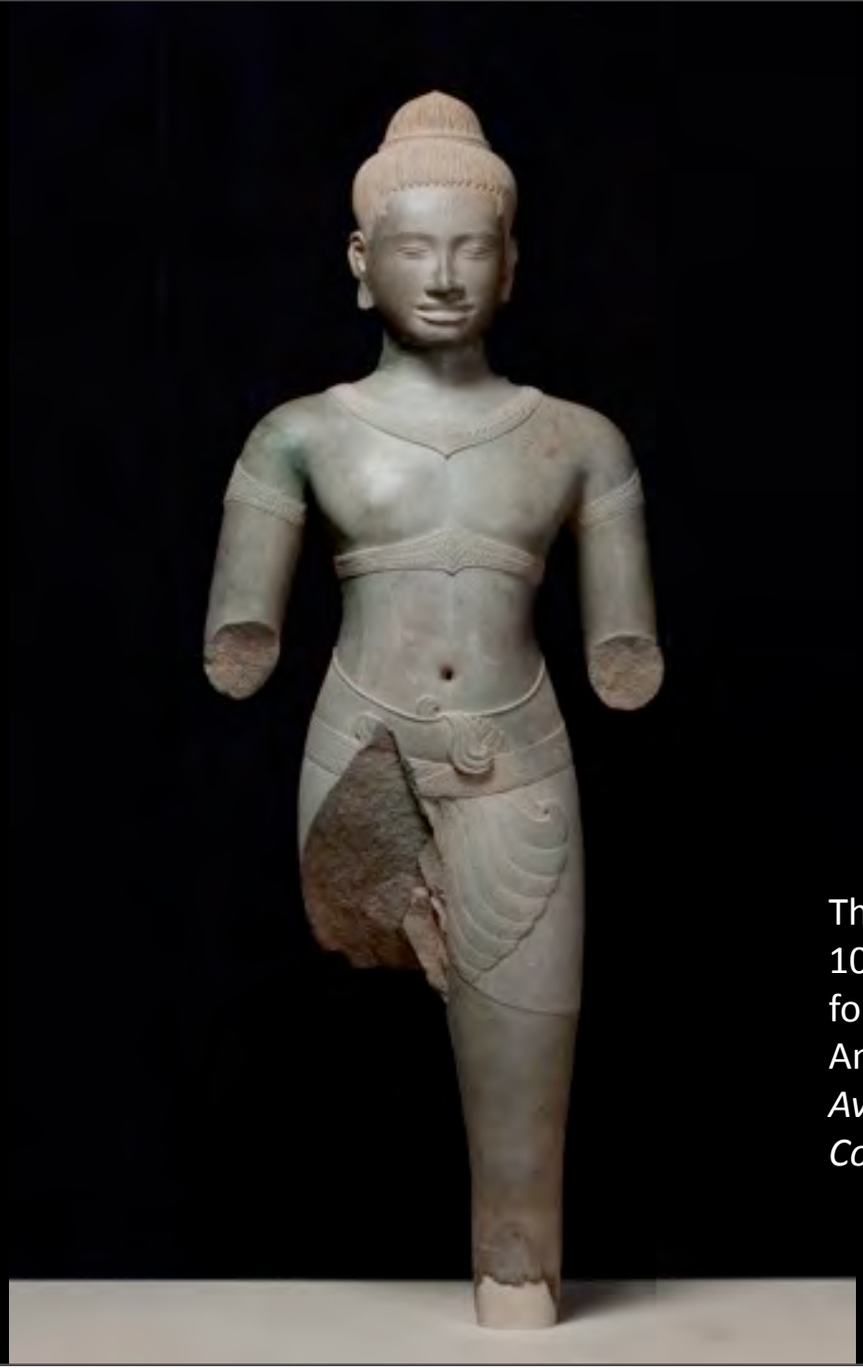


Ritual vessel (zun or gui) in the shape of a rhinoceros, Shang dynasty (1600–1050 BCE), probably 1100–1050 BCE. China. Bronze. The AVery Brundage Collection, B60b1+.

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Some with a patina of age



The Hindu deity Shiva, 1000–1100. Cambodia; former kingdom of Angkor. Sandstone. *The Avery Brundage Collection*, B66S2.

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Ancient objects, without intellectual property concerns



Vaishravana (Bishamonten), Guardian King of the North, approx. 1615–1700. Japan. Colors and gold on wood. The Avery Brundage Collection, B60S170+

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So we wanted to try it.

This was a risk. We weren't certain of the benefits. But it was an opportunity to try something new and cutting edge. My next step was to talk to Forrest to understand the goals and risks from a curatorial perspective.

Forrest saw the opportunities for the user experience, and immediately came up with new ideas for using this in interpretation.

This gave us certainty, AND the ability to execute.



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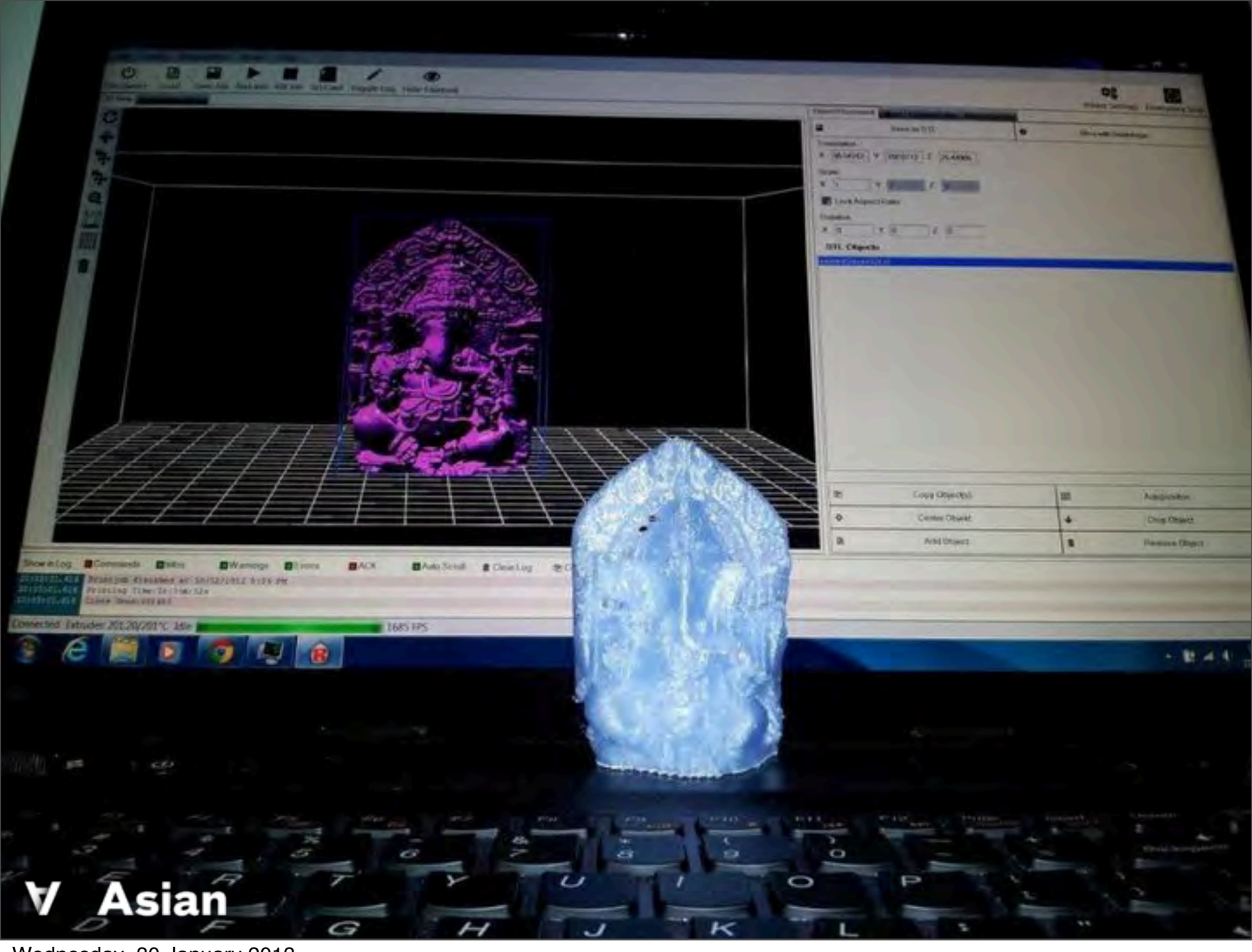
So we partnered with Autodesk and members of the Makerbot community to stage a Scanathon.



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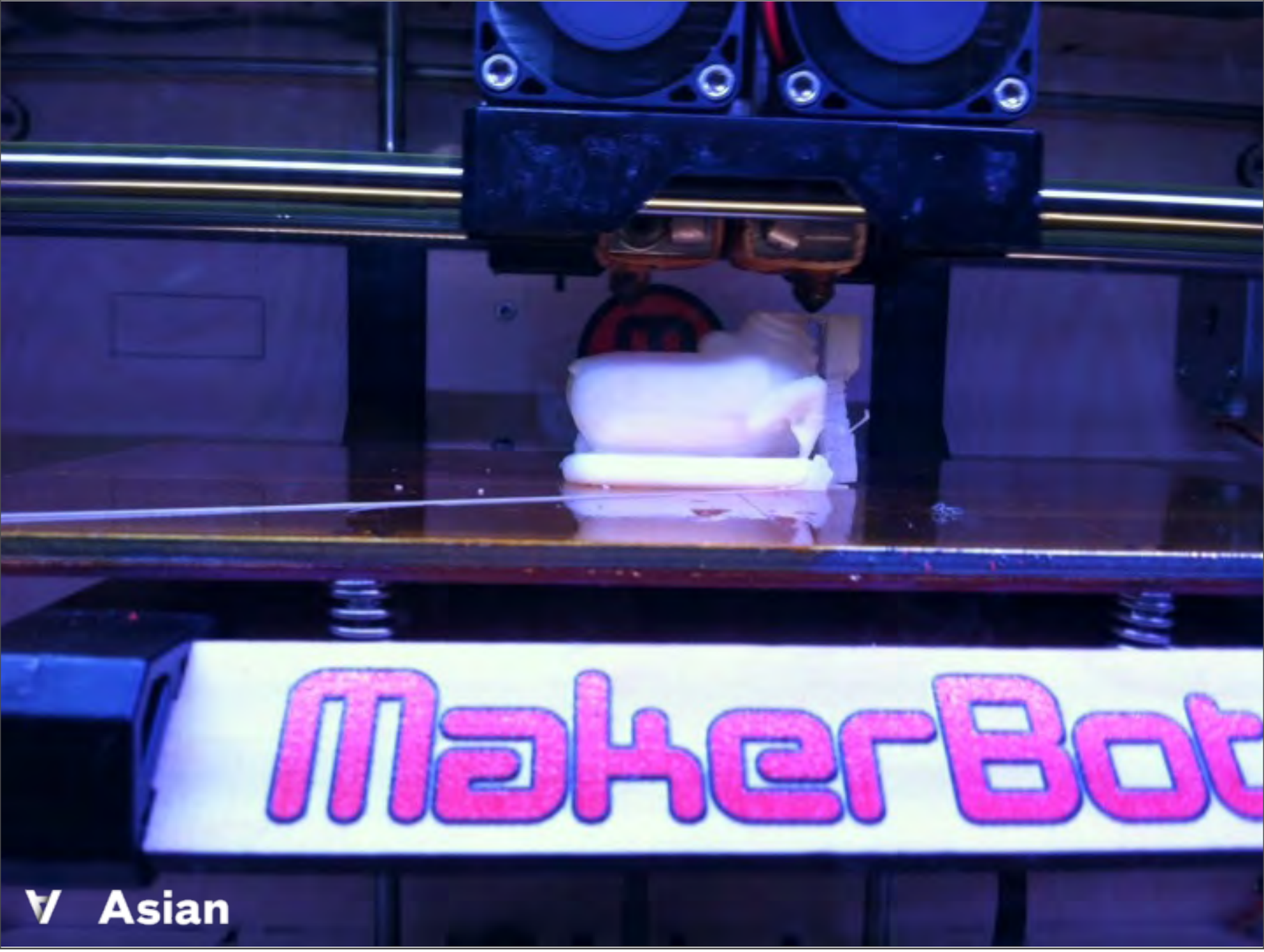
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Artists scanned our objects in situ using Autodesk's free 123D Catch software. Autodesk had just released the iPhone app so we had people scanning using iPhones, iPads and SLRs.



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People loved
it.

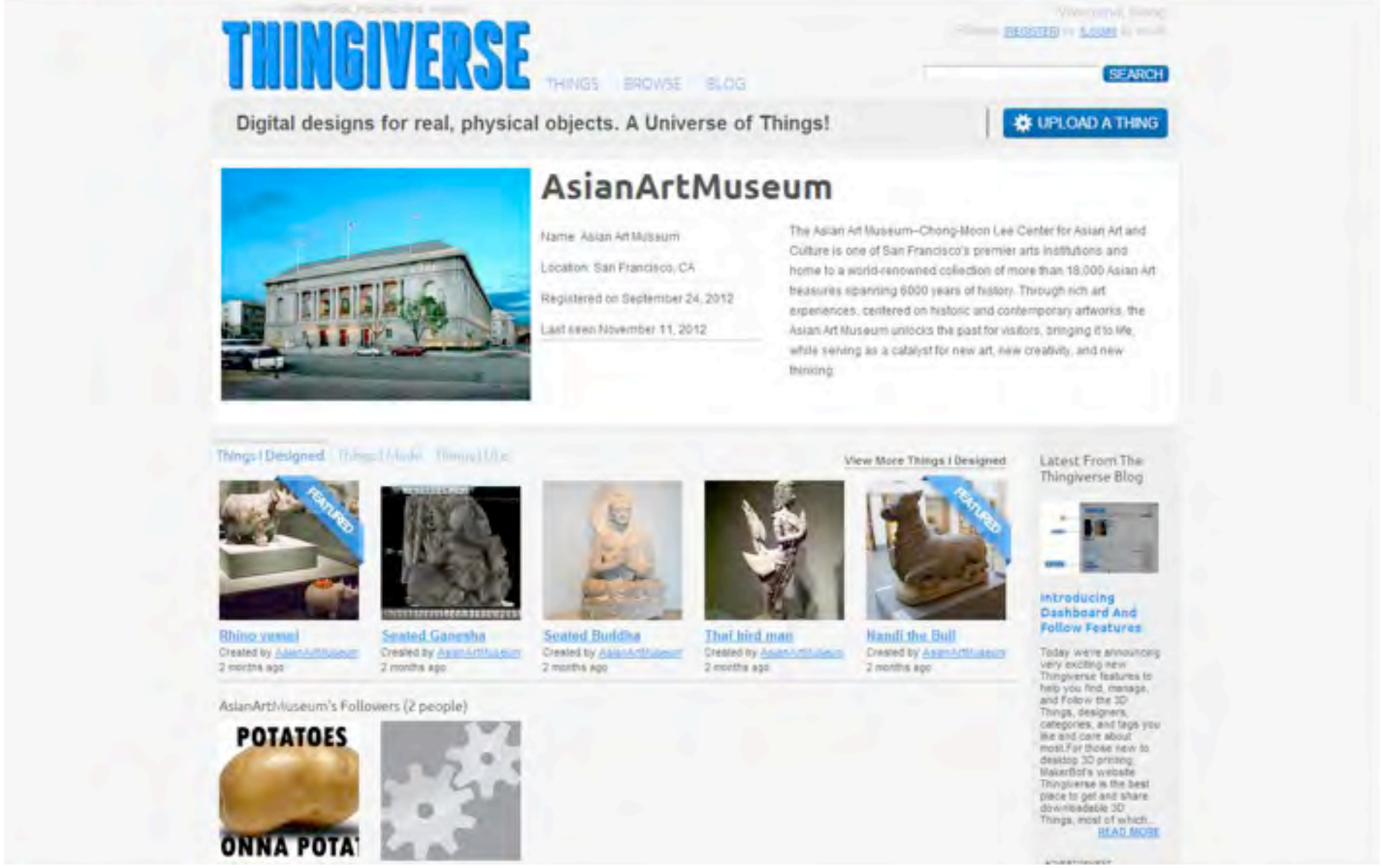


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We were able to print some objects on the spot, and others were printed overnight.

We see real possibilities to use this technology for our visitors:

- Perhaps the digital models could be on tablets in the galleries, allowing people to rotate the objects to see hidden details
- Perhaps we can use it to create low-cost Augmented Reality
- Perhaps the models can become the basis for animation
- We've also had feedback from staff that being able to hold the printed object has given them a perspective on the real thing
- And our conservation department is experimenting with using 3D printing instead of more traditional methods of fabrication



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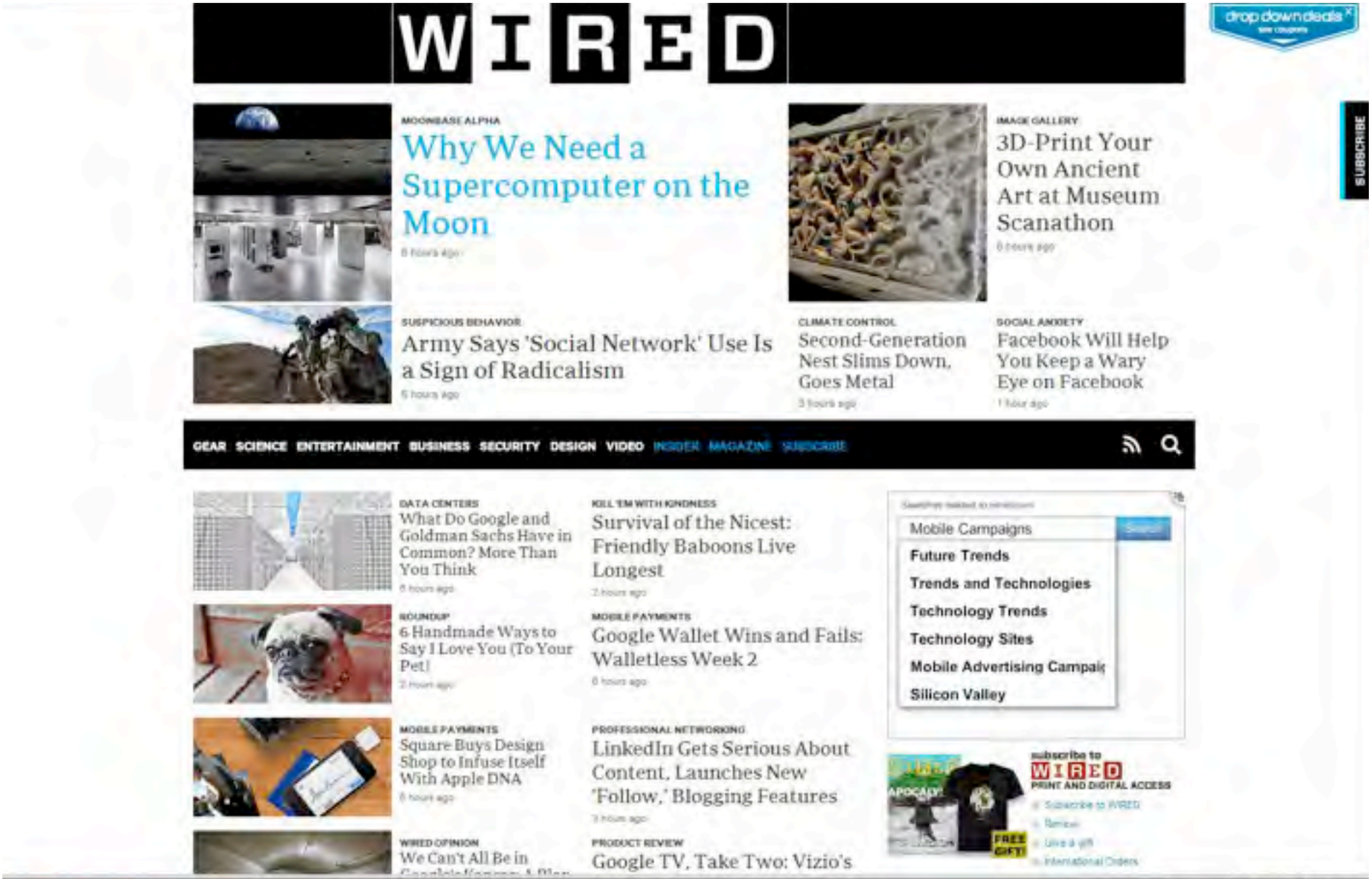
We uploaded the digital models to Thingiverse, and made them available under a Creative Commons license for people to use.



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And we've seen examples of people inspired by our objects to create new artworks. We're planning to do more to encourage this.



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And we made the homepage of Wired.



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And let's remember that Forrest was the one who made this possible.

So far, I've focused on the things that require thought, effort and time. But the astute among you will have noticed that I haven't mentioned money.



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Where to invest financially is a huge question for us, as I'm sure it is for many of you.

So I wanted to share some thoughts on where we're putting the big bucks.

There was a hige amount of frustration about the fact that other museums were doing amazing digital things. We felt we could never catch up.

Everyone else is still moving.



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Here's the problem with playing catch-up: everyone else is still moving.

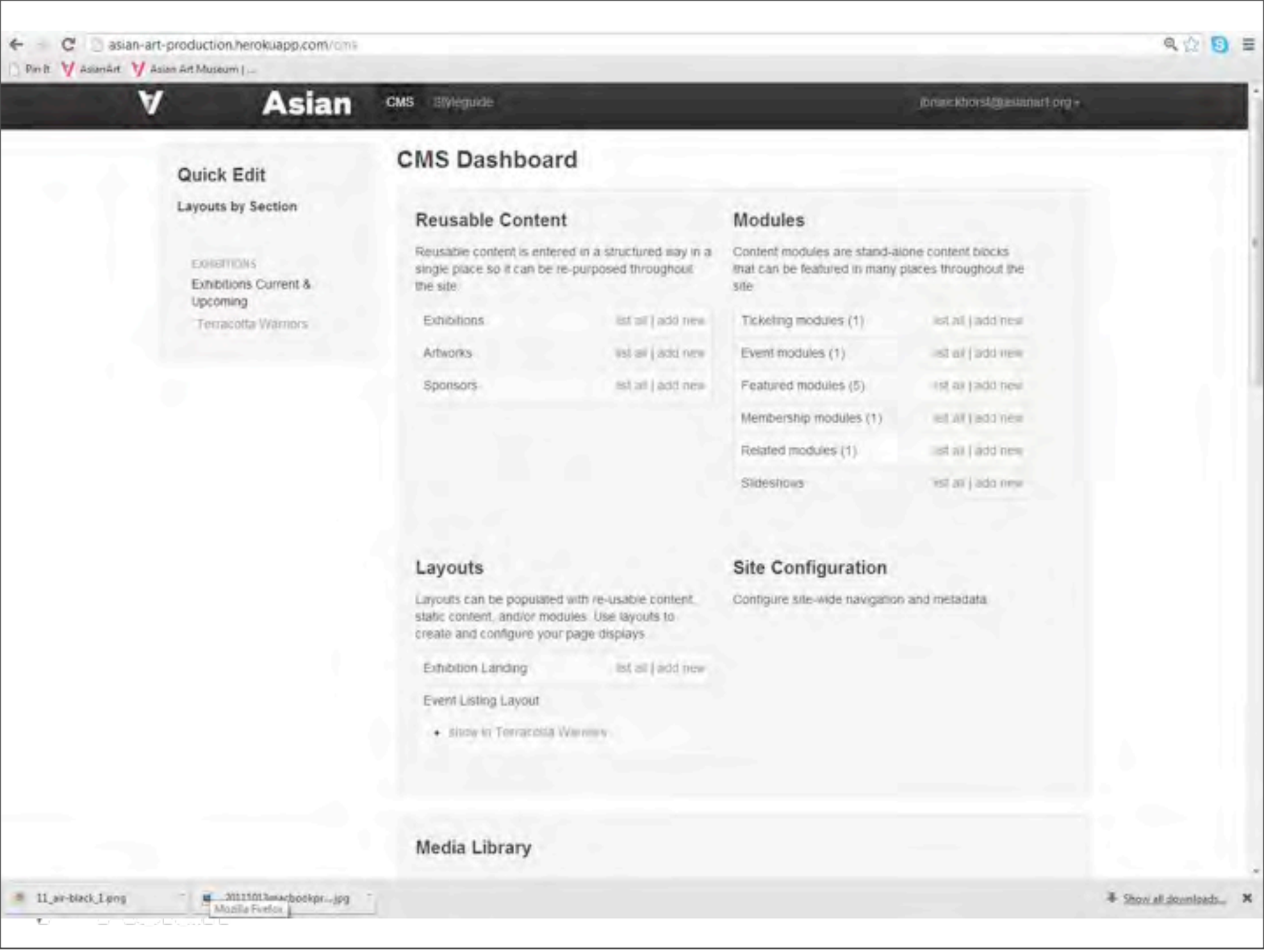


Frog on sandal, netsuke, approx. 1800–1900. Japan. Wood. *The Avery Brundage Collection*, B70Y1525.

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We had to leap frog. But you can't leapfrog off quicksand.

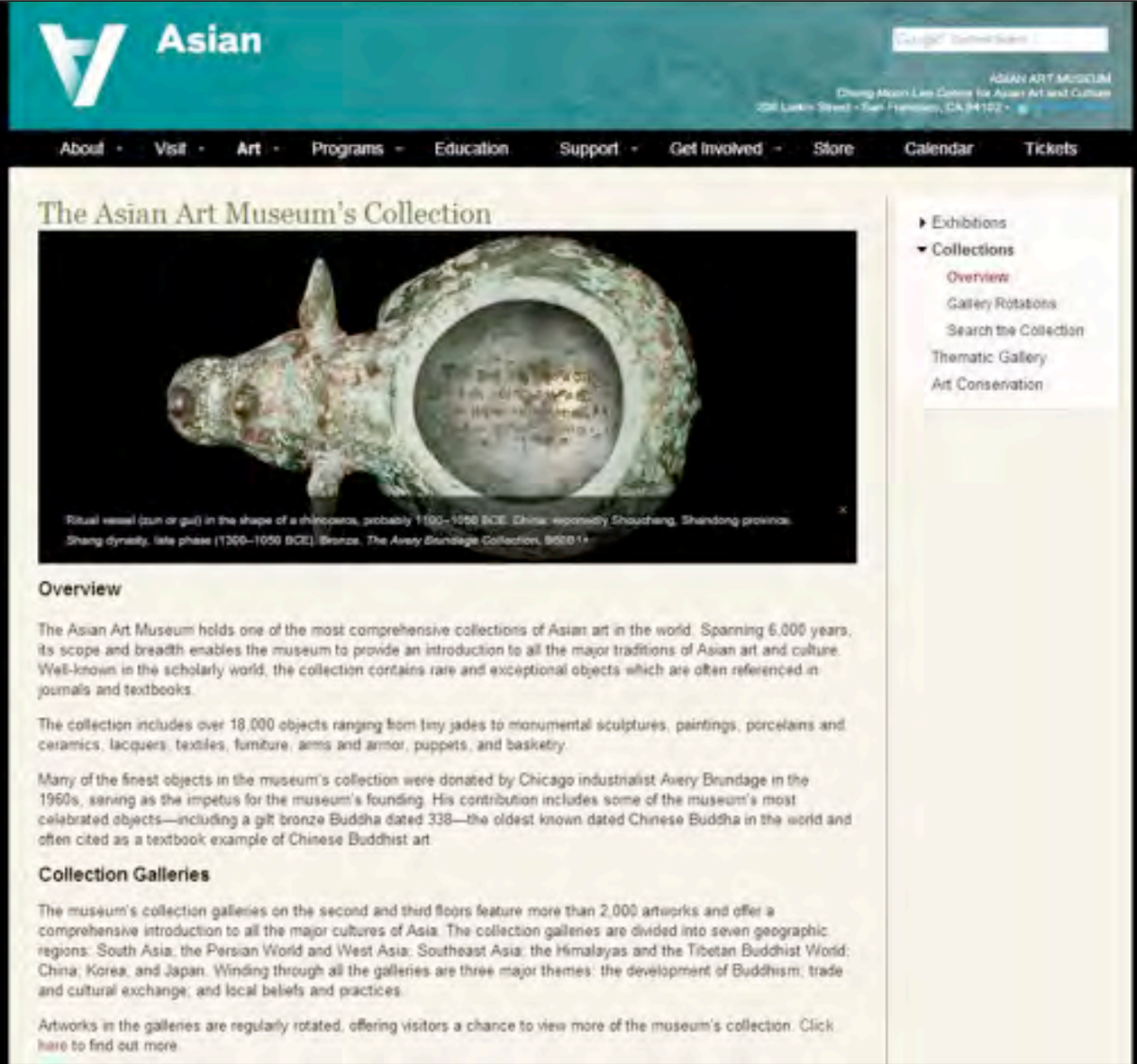


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We knew we had to invest in infrastructure. In particular, we needed a web content management system. We didn't have one. At all.

Unfortunately, infrastructure projects aren't very sexy. But we knew it was fundamental to our ability to realize Jay's vision. That was a critical decision. It gave us focus for fundraising and budget allocation.

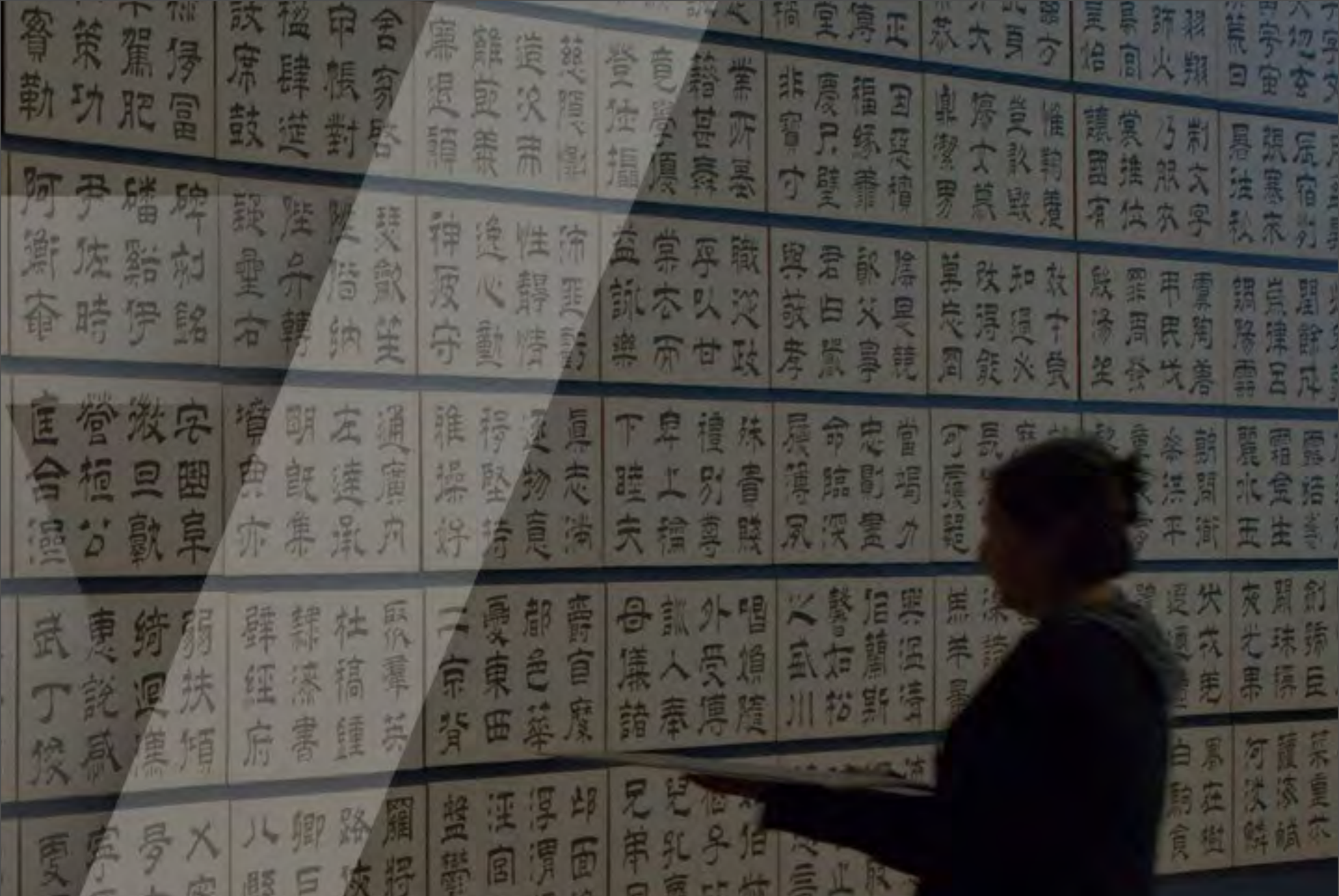
We had another important realization. We were giving short shrift to the way we presented ourselves online.



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We'd never had the resources to really deliver on the brand promise online. But think about it: would you cut corners on the way you present your art? Or on interpretation in your exhibitions?



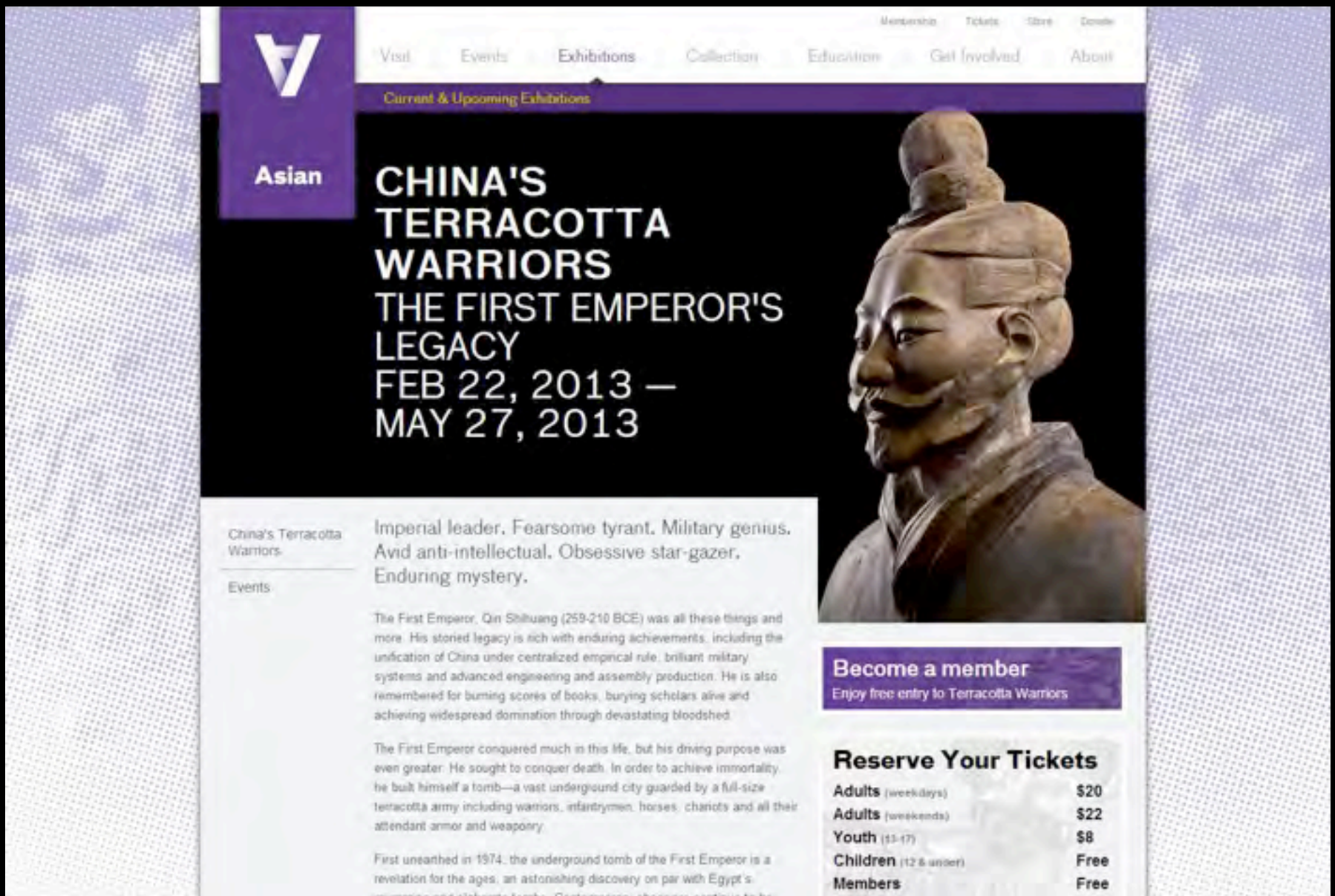
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Neither would we.

For a lot of people, your website is the first experience they have of your insitution.

It needs to look great. It needs to be intuitive. It needs design.

That’s not just visual design; it’s the design of the whole user experience. So we knew that design was another non-negotiable for us.



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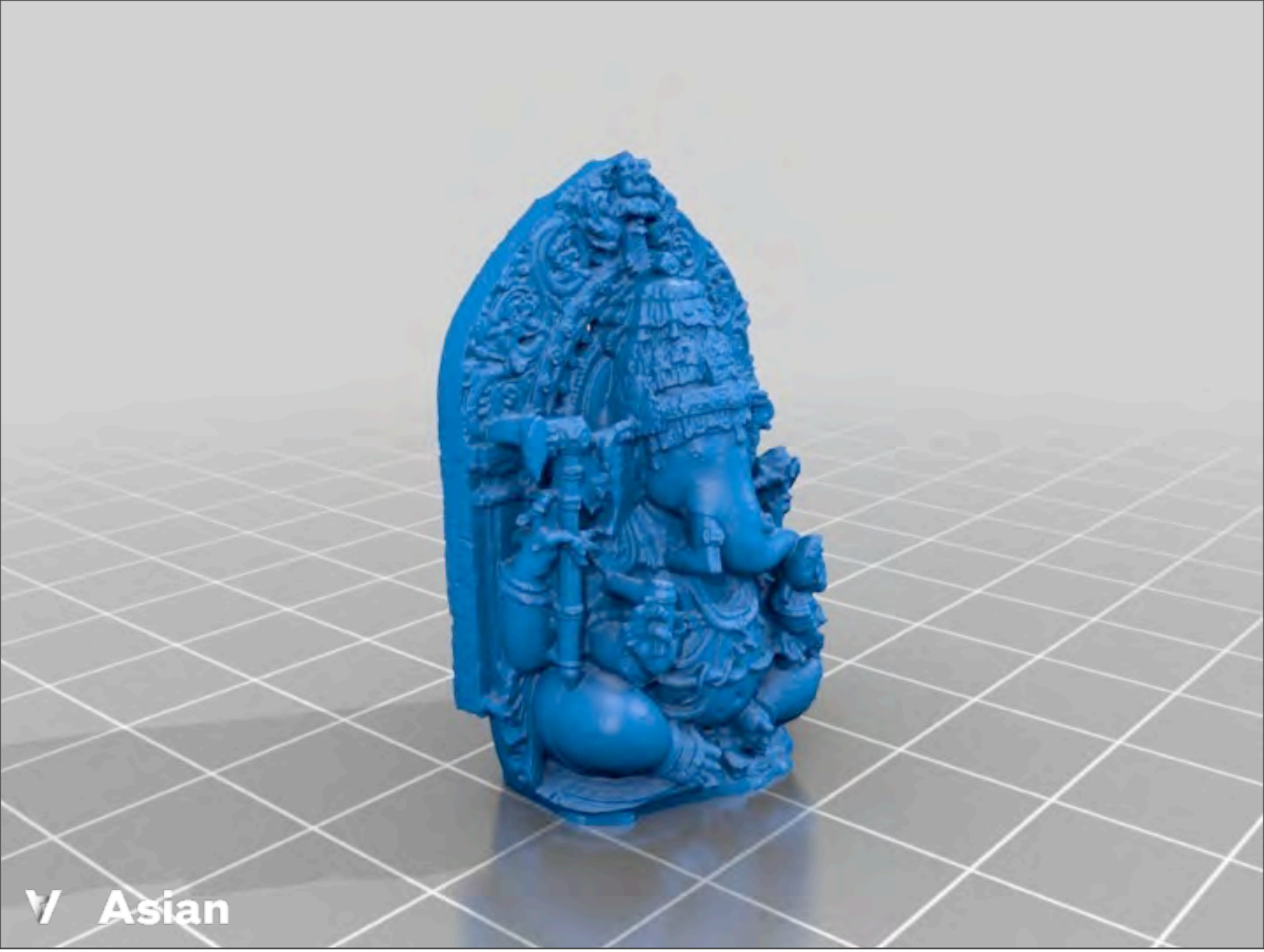
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That's why we are making investments where we are - in a content management system and a site redesign. What you see here is the tip of the iceberg.



We know that's not enough. The website is core to our digital experience right now, but it's not the cutting edge. It's more of a minimum requirement.

And it doesn't offer anything special to the 61% with the smartphones. So we have work still to do.



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But if you'd told me six months ago that we'd be exploring ways to help visitors interact with our objects using 3D scanning and printing....



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If you'd told me we'd be dabbling in Augmented Reality.

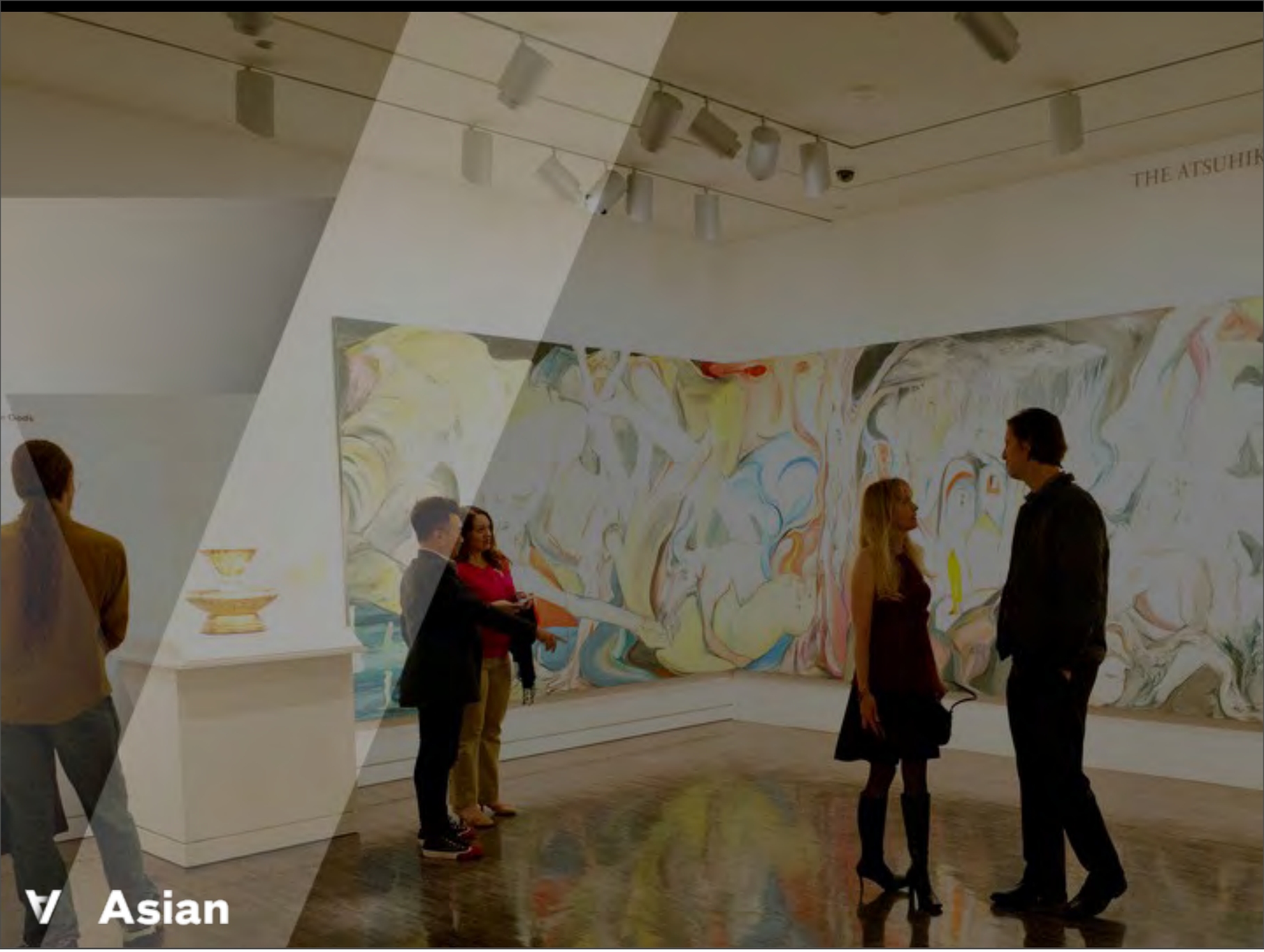


Laughing Budai (Japanese: Hotei), approx. 1800–1900, by Masaharu, Japanese. Japan. Ivory with detail staining. *The Avery Brundage Collection*, B70Y651.

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I would have laughed.



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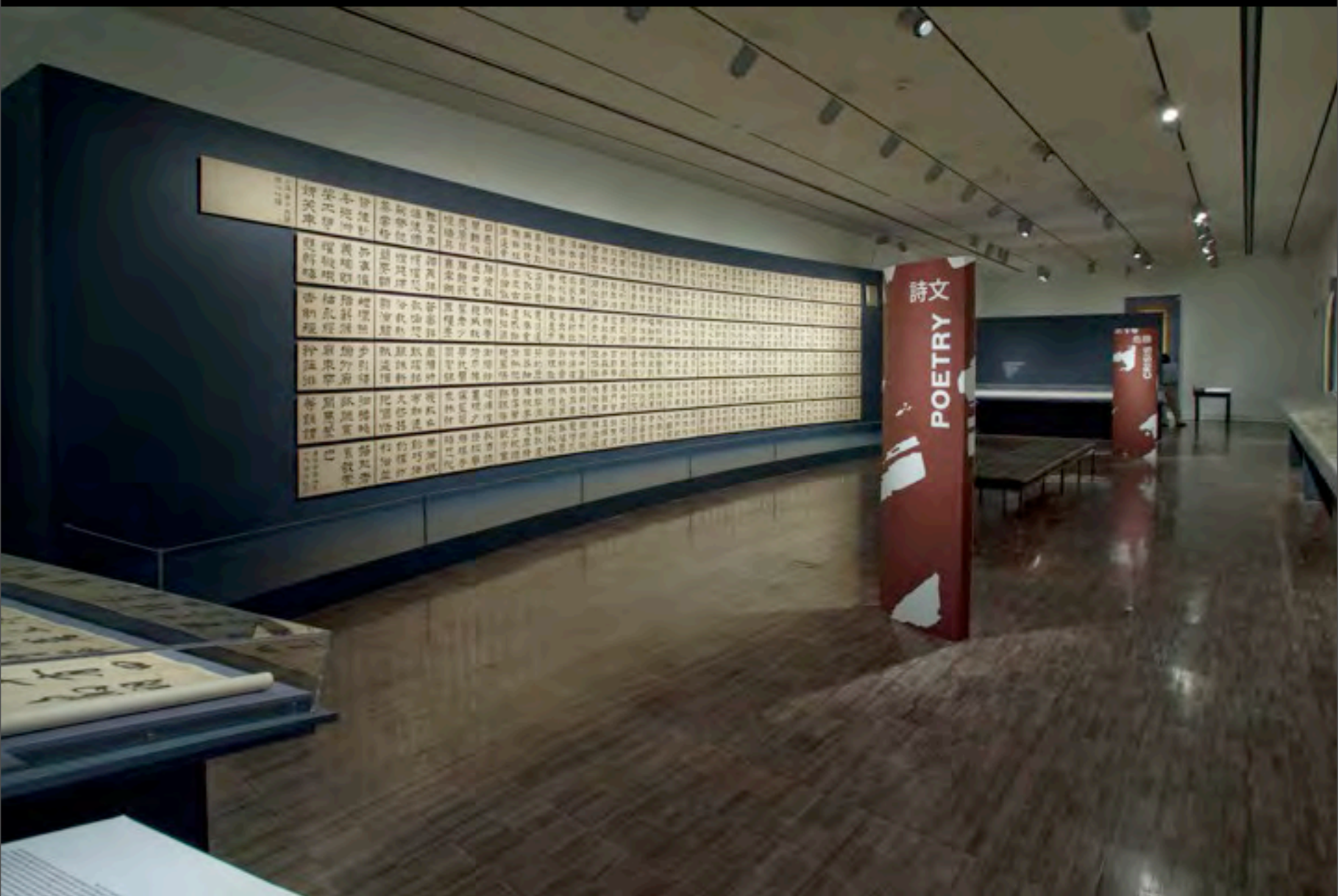
We got here by making sure the right people were doing the right work



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By identifying our champions



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And by ruthlessly prioritizing our major projects.



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We know we have a ways to go. We are experimenting with low or no-cost technology that will help us learn:

- How well we can execute on these types of projects
- Which types of technology, experience and platforms best serve our storytelling needs

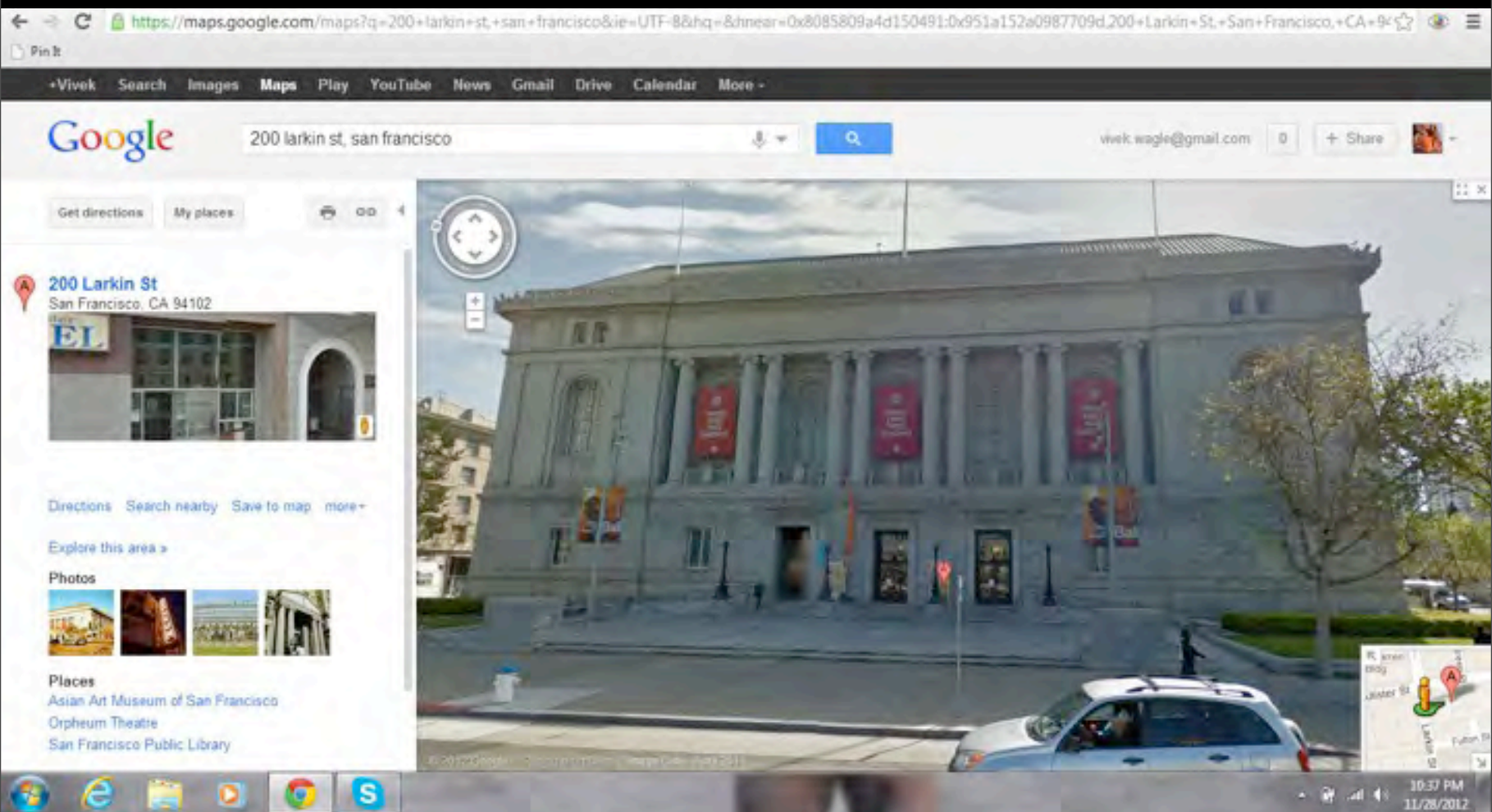


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And we're continuing to revise and refine our strategy, especially in mobile, so that we can keep investing wisely in our larger projects.

Because we know that digital isn't just a tool, and it certainly isn't a gimmick.



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It's no longer separate from the physical experience. It's an integral part of how people experience the world.



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Questions from the audience